…will take money from everybody. From the British today from the Russians tomorrow or from the French or the Germans or anyone else. But they will never do anything for the money. You may buy their country from them six times over but you will never get it.[15]

By the end of the year this frustration had led Rothstein to address a letter to the shah complaining about the prime minister and stating that the Soviet legation could not work with a Persian government so hostile as the present one.[16] This letter was to cause a definite cooling in Soviet-Persian relations, much to the happiness of Loraine, who noted with satisfaction that the Russians 'can always be depended on to make gaffes'.[17] Too late did Rothstein realise he had overstepped the mark.[18]

The frustration with the Persian government was more than likely compounded by the little progress that was being made in advancing Communism within Persia. On his arrival in Tehran in April 1921, Rothstein had immediately begun agitating among the Persian population. One of his first acts had been to open the Russian embassy grounds, Atabak Park, to the public, thereby immediately increasing his legation's popularity among the Persian people.[19] Indeed, the appointment of Rothstein to Tehran is perhaps indicative of the seriousness with which the Bolsheviks now viewed relations with Persia. Compared to Bravin, Rothstein was a heavyweight diplomat; he had lived and studied in England and taken part in the labour movement there so he understood well how to deal with his British counterparts in Tehran.[20] He was also close to both Lenin and Trotsky and 'his voice carried weight in the highest quarters of the Soviet hierarchy'.[21] By the time Rothstein had arrived in Tehran, the Second Comintern Congress had also resolved some of the conflicting policies the Bolsheviks had hitherto been pursuing in Persia. All of which meant that, in contrast to Bravin, who had been given no credentials and no funding, Rothstein was well-financed and was able to expand his staff and open consulates in almost all the major cities of Persia.